

THE BEST OF THE BATS

Other than Gambhir, the Gen Next batsmen could have done more

	M	R	AVG	100	50
M.S. DHONI	10	347	69.40	0	2
G. GAMBHIR	10	440	55.00	2	1
S. TENDULKAR	10	399	44.33	1	2
ROHIT SHARMA	10	235	33.57	0	2
YUVRAJ SINGH	9	202	22.44	0	1
ROBIN UTHAPPA	10	142	20.28	0	1
IRFAN PATHAN	10	118	19.66	0	0
V SEHWAG	5	81	16.20	0	0

THE STRIKE FORCE

India's success in the CB series rested on the ability of its bowlers to do early damage

	M	B/B	W	AVG	ECON	SR
PRAVEEN KUMAR	4	4/31	10	17.50	4.37	24.0
ISHANT SHARMA	9	4/38	14	20.35	4.58	26.6
S. SREESANTH	7	3/31	9	25.77	5.75	26.8
IRFAN PATHAN	10	4/41	11	34.27	5.49	37.4
HARBHAJAN SINGH	10	2/38	8	34.62	4.25	48.8
MUNAF PATEL	3	1/31	2	60.0	4.44	81.0
V SEHWAG	5	1/28	1	66.0	5.07	78.0
YUVRAJ SINGH	9	1/18	1	120.0	4.61	156.0

M: matches, R: runs, AVG: average, B/B: best bowling, W: wickets, ECON: economy rate, SR: strike rate

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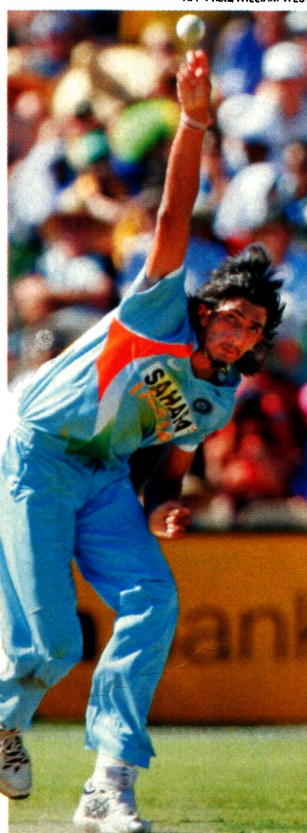
AFP Photo/WILLIAM WEST

able to pull a bunch of young cricketers together using what is becoming the hallmark of his captaincy: the ability to show faith in his least-regarded player and take the difficult decision.

Kumar went from obscure first-class workhorse to Australian scourge when he was given the new ball and told by Dhoni, "Khul ke daal, bindaas daal. (bowl with freedom)." Even though it meant fielding eight players who had played no ODI's in Australia until the CB series, Dhoni thought nothing of dropping Virender Sehwag to play five bowlers in the finals.

Many believe that this surge by younger men has completely shut the door on veterans like Rahul Dravid, Sourav Ganguly and V.V.S. Laxman. Patil says, "That is their decision", but the selectors could well decide that if the rookies picked by them could survive in Australia, they can survive pretty much anything.

The Indian selectors rarely feature on anyone's Diwali gift list barring probably each others', but their most recent decisions have been, in hindsight, virtually visionary. "Cricket is a game of results," laughs Patil, and the CB series results means the unthinkable has happened: for once, the Aussies do not appear to have



Forced to test its bench strength, India found MATCH-WINNERS in its ranks.

all the ideas and all the answers. Former Australian skipper Ian Chappell said, "Perhaps where Australia need to look is just across the bench—at India... (Australia) have got to get a bit younger."

As the lights went down over the Gabba, Ponting still insisted Harbhajan

Singh, who broke open the Australian innings in both finals, had not thrived with pressure on him. "Overall we've played him pretty well," Ponting maintained. In fact, the Australians tried too hard to play Harbhajan to the exclusion of all else. Their former captain Steve Waugh said that after the Harbhajan-Symonds spat in Sydney, Ponting's team was "searching for equilibrium". He could have said that about much around them as well. For the second final, Channel 9, pioneers of cricket television, inaugurated their latest innovation, the Bhajicam, the camera that only tracks the home team's target of choice.

The final word must come from the exchange between Ponting and Harbhajan. Constantly challenged by the Australian skipper, "show me what you've got," when he went into bat in Adelaide, Harbhajan snapped back, "Whatever I've shown in the middle has been better than what you've done so far, mate."

It is the bait and the barb that Australia throws at all its cricketing tourists—show us what you've got. All through a steamy, ill-tempered, riveting summer, Australia was shown something it had not seen for a very long time—a sign of its own frailty. ■